

with naming it. The first thing D'Artagnan perceived after the fine trees, the May sun gilding the sides of the green hills, the long rows of feather-topped trees which stretched out towards Compiègne, was a large rolling box, pushed forward by two servants and dragged by two others. In this box there was an enormous green-and-gold thing, which went along the smiling glades of the park, thus dragged and pushed. This thing, at a distance, could not be distinguished, and signified absolutely nothing; nearer, it was a hogshhead muffed in gold-bound green cloth; when close, it was a man, or rather a poussa, the inferior extremity of whom, spreading over the interior of the box, entirely filled it; when still closer, the man was Mousqueton—Mousqueton, with gray hair and a face as red as Punchinello's.

'Pardieu!' cried D'Artagnan; 'why, that's my dear Monsieur Mousqueton!'

'Ah!' cried the fat man—'ah! what happiness! what joy! There's M. d'Artagnan. Stop, you rascals!' These last words were addressed to the lackeys who pushed and dragged him. The box stopped, and the four lackeys, with a precision quite military, took off their laced hats and ranged themselves behind it.

'Oh, Monsieur d'Artagnan!' said Mousqueton, 'why can I not embrace your knees? But I have become impotent, as you see.'

'Dame! my dear Mousqueton, it is age.'

'No, monsieur, it is not age; it is infirmities—troubles.'

'Troubles! you, Mousqueton?' said D'Artagnan, making the tour of the box; 'are you out of your mind, my dear friend? Thank God! you are as hearty as a three-hundred-year-old oak.'

'Ah! but my legs, monsieur, my legs!' groaned the faithful servant.

'What's the matter with your legs?'

'Oh, they will no longer bear me!'

'Ah, the ungrateful things! And yet you feed them well, Mousqueton, apparently.'

'Alas, yes! They can reproach me with nothing in that respect,' said Mousqueton, with a sigh; 'I have always done what I could for my poor body; I am not selfish.' And Mousqueton sighed afresh.

'I wonder whether Mousqueton wants to be a baron, too, as he sighs after that fashion?' thought D'Artagnan.

'Mon Dieu, monsieur!' said Mousqueton, as if rousing himself from a painful reverie; 'how happy monseigneur will be that you have thought of him!'

'Kind Porthos!' cried D'Artagnan, 'I am anxious to embrace him.'

'Oh!' said Mousqueton, much affected, 'I shall certainly write to him.'

'What!' cried D'Artagnan, 'you will write to him?'

'This very day; I shall not delay it an hour.'

'Is he not here, then?'

'No, monsieur.'

'But is he near at hand?—is he far off?'

'Oh, can I tell, monsieur, can I tell?'

'Mordieux!' cried the musketeer, stamping with his foot, 'I am unfortunate. Porthos is such a stay-at-home!'

'Monsieur, there is not a more sedentary man that monseigneur, but—'

'But what?'

'When a friend presses you—'

'A friend?'

'Doubtless—the worthy M. d'Herblay.'

'What, has Aramis pressed Porthos?'

'This is how the thing happened, Monsieur d'Artagnan. M. d'Herblay wrote to monseigneur—'

'Indeed!'

'A letter, monsieur, such a pressing letter that it threw us all into a bustle.'

'Tell me all about it, my dear friend,' said D'Artagnan; 'but remove these people a little further off first.'

Mousqueton shouted, 'Fall back, you fellows,' with such powerful lungs that the breath, without the words, would have been sufficient to disperse the four lackeys. D'Artagnan seated himself on the shaft of the box and opened his ears. 'Monsieur,' said Mousqueton, 'monseigneur, then, received a letter from M. le Vicaire-General d'Herblay, eight or nine days ago; it was the day of the rustic pleasures, yes, it must have been Wednesday.'

'What do you mean?' said D'Artagnan. 'The day of rustic pleasures?'

'Yes, monsieur; we have so many pleasures to take in this delightful country, that we were encumbered by them; so much so, that we have been forced to regulate the distribution of them.'

'How easily do I recognize Porthos's love of order in that! Now, that idea would never have occurred to me; but then I am not encumbered with pleasures.'

'We were, though,' said Mousqueton.

'And how did you regulate the matter, let me know?' said D'Artagnan.

'It is rather long, monsieur.'

'Never mind, we have plenty of time; and you speak so well, my dear Mousqueton, that it is really a pleasure to hear you.'

'It is true,' said Mousqueton, with a sigh of satisfaction, which emanated evidently from the justice which had been rendered him, 'it is true I have made great progress in the company of monseigneur.'

'I am waiting for the distribution of the pleasures, Mousqueton, and with impatience. I want to know if I have arrived on a lucky day.'

'Oh, Monsieur d'Artagnan,' said Mousqueton in a melancholy tone, 'since monseigneur's departure all the pleasures have gone too!'

'Well, my dear Mousqueton, refresh your memory.'

'With what day shall I begin?'

'Eh, pardieux! begin with Sunday; that is the Lord's day.'

'Sunday, monsieur?'

'Yes.'

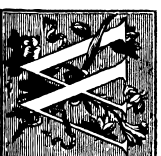
'Sunday pleasures are religious: monseigneur goes to mass, makes the bread-offering, and has discourses and instructions made to him by his almoner-in-ordinary. That is not very amusing, but we expect a Carmelite from Paris who will do the duty of our almoner; and who, we are assured, speaks very well, which will keep us awake, whereas our present almoner always sends us to sleep. These are Sunday religious pleasures. On Monday, worldly pleasures.'

'Ah, ah!' said D'Artagnan, 'what do you mean by that? Let us have a glimpse at your worldly pleasures.'

'Monsieur, on Monday we go into the world; we pay and receive visits, we play on the lute, we dance, we make verses, and burn a little incense in honour of the ladies.'

Chapter XVIII

In Which D'Artagnan Seeks Porthos, and Only Finds Mousqueton



WHEN D'Artagnan had perfectly convinced himself that the absence of the Vicar-General d'Herblay was real, and that his friend was not to be found at Melun or in its vicinity, he left Bazin without regret, cast an ill-natured glance at the magnificent château de Vaux, which was beginning to shine with that splendour which brought on its ruin, and, compressing his lips like a man full of mistrust and suspicion, he put spurs to his pied horse, saying, 'Well, well! I have still Pierrefonds left, and there I shall find the best man and the best filled coffer. And that is all I want, for I have an idea of my own.'

We will spare our readers the prosaic incidents of D'Artagnan's journey, which terminated on the morning of the third day within sight of Pierrefonds. D'Artagnan came by the way of Nanteuil-le-Haudouin and Crepy. At a distance he perceived the Castle of Louis of Orleans, which, having become part of the crown domain, was kept by an old concierge. This was one of those marvellous manors of the middle ages, with walls twenty feet in thickness, and a hundred in height.

D'Artagnan rode slowly past its walls, measured its towers with his eye and descended into the valley. From afar he looked down upon the château of Porthos, situated on the shores of a small lake, and contiguous to a magnificent forest. It was the same place we have already had the honour of describing to our readers; we shall therefore satisfy ourselves

*Chapter 18: In Which D'Arragnan Seeks Portbos, and Only Finds
Mousqueton*

'Peste! that is the height of gallantry,' said the musketeer, who was obliged to call to his aid all the strength of his facial muscles to suppress an enormous inclination to laugh.

'Tuesday, learned pleasures,'

'Good!' cried D'Arragnan. 'What are they? Detail them, my dear Mousqueton.'

'Monseigneur has bought a sphere or globe, which I shall show you; it fills all the perimeter of the great tower, except a gallery which he has had built over the sphere: there are little strings and brass wires to which the sun and moon are hooked. It all turns; and that is very beautiful. Monseigneur points out to me the seas and distant countries. We don't intend to visit them, but it is very interesting.'

'Interesting! yes, that's the word,' repeated D'Arragnan. 'And Wednesday?'

'Rustic pleasures, as I have had the honour to tell you, monsieur le chevalier. We look over monseigneur's sheep and goats; we make the shepherds dance to pipes and reeds, as is written in a book monseigneur has in his library, which is called "Bergeries." The author died about a month ago.'

'Monsieur Racan, perhaps,' said D'Arragnan.

'Yes, that was his name—M. Racan. But that is not all: we angle in the little canal, after which we dine, crowned with flowers. That is Wednesday.'

'Peste!' said D'Arragnan; 'you don't divide your pleasures badly. And Thursday?—what can be left for poor Thursday?'

'It is not very unfortunate, monsieur,' said Mousqueton, smiling. 'Thursday, Olympian pleasures. Ah, monsieur, that is superb! We get together all monseigneur's young vassals, and we make them throw the disc, wrestle, and run races. Monseigneur can't run now, no more can I; but monseigneur throws the disc as nobody else can throw it. And when he does deal a blow, oh, that proves a misfortune!'

'How so?'

'Yes, monsieur, we were obliged to renounce the cestus. He cracked heads; he broke jaws—beat in ribs. It was charming sport; but nobody was willing to play with him.'

'Then his wrist—'

‘Oh, monsieur, firmer than ever. Monseigneur gets a trifle weaker in his legs,—he confesses that himself; but his strength has all taken refuge in his arms, so that—’

‘So that he can knock down bullocks, as he used to formerly?’

‘Monsieur, better than that—he bears in walls. Lately, after having supped with one of our farmers—you know how popular and kind monseigneur is—after supper, as a joke, he struck the wall a blow. The wall crumbled away beneath his hand, the roof fell in, and three men and an old woman were stifled.’

‘Good God, Mousqueton! And your master?’

‘Oh, monseigneur, a little skin was rubbed off his head. We bathed the wounds with some water which the monks gave us. But there was nothing the matter with his hand.’

‘Nothing?’

‘No, nothing, monsieur.’

‘Deuce take the Olympic pleasures! They must cost your master too dear; for widows and orphans—’

‘They all had pensions, monsieur; a tenth of monseigneur’s revenue was spent in that way.’

‘Then pass on to Friday,’ said D’Artagnan.

‘Friday, noble and warlike pleasures. We hunt, we fence, we dress falcons and break horses. Then, Saturday is the day for intellectual pleasures: we adorn our minds; we look at monseigneur’s pictures and statues; we write, even, and trace plans: and then we fire monseigneur’s cannon.’

‘You draw plans, and fire cannon?’

‘Yes, monsieur.’

‘Why, my friend,’ said D’Artagnan, ‘M. du Vallon, in truth, possesses the most subtle and amiable mind that I know. But there is one kind of pleasure you have forgotten, it appears to me.’

‘What is that, monsieur?’ asked Mousqueton, with anxiety.

‘The material pleasures.’

Mousqueton coloured. ‘What do you mean by that, monsieur?’ said he, casting down his eyes.

‘I mean the table—good wine—evenings occupied in passing the bottle.’

‘Ah, monsieur, we don’t reckon those pleasures,—we practice them every day.’

‘I might easily see it was not the king,’ said D’Artagnan; ‘people don’t laugh so heartily when the king passes. Hola, Bazin!’ cried he to his neighbour, three-quarters of whose body still hung out of the window, to follow the carriage with his eyes as long as he could. ‘What is all that about?’

‘It is M. Fouquet,’ said Bazin, in a patronizing tone.

‘And all those people?’

‘That is the court of M. Fouquet.’

‘Oh, oh!’ said D’Artagnan; ‘what would M. de Mazarin say to that if he heard it?’ And he returned to his bed, asking himself how Aramis always contrived to be protected by the most powerful personages in the kingdom. ‘Is it that he has more luck than I, or that I am a greater fool than he? Bah! That was the concluding word by the aid of which D’Artagnan, having become wise, now terminated every thought and every period of his style. Formerly he said, ‘Mordieux!’ which was a prick of the spur; but now he had become older, and he murmured that philosophical ‘Bah!’ which served as a bridle to all the passions.

the sun prevent our seeing the large stars, which are also suns, at a little greater distance from our earth,—that is all.’

As D’Artagnan delighted, both from pleasure and system, in making people talk about things which interested him, he fenced in his best style with Master Bazin, but it was pure loss of time; beyond the tiresome and hyperbolic praises of monsieur le surintendant of the finances, Bazin, who, on his side, was on his guard, afforded nothing but platitudes to the curiosity of D’Artagnan, so that our musketeer, in a tolerably bad humour, desired to go to bed as soon as he had supped. D’Artagnan was introduced by Bazin into a mean chamber, in which there was a poor bed; but D’Artagnan was not fastidious in that respect. He had been told that Aramis had taken away the key of his own private apartment, and as he knew Aramis was a very particular man, and had generally many things to conceal in his apartment, he had not been surprised. He, therefore, although it seemed comparatively even harder, attacked the bed as bravely as he had done the fowl; and, as he had as good an inclination to sleep as he had had to eat, he took scarcely longer time to be snoring harmoniously than he had employed in picking the last bones of the bird.

Since he was no longer in the service of any one, D’Artagnan had promised himself to indulge in sleeping as soundly as he had formerly slept lightly; but with whatever good faith D’Artagnan had made himself this promise, and whatever desire he might have to keep it religiously, he was awakened in the middle of the night by a loud noise of carriages, and servants on horseback. A sudden illumination flashed over the walls of his chamber; he jumped out of bed and ran to the window in his shirt. ‘Can the king be coming this way?’ he thought, rubbing his eyes; ‘in truth, such a suite can only be attached to royalty.’

‘Vive le monsieur le surintendant!’ cried, or rather vociferated, from a window on the ground-floor, a voice which he recognized as Bazin’s, who at the same time waved a handkerchief with one hand, and held a large candle in the other. D’Artagnan then saw something like a brilliant human form leaning out of the principal carriage; at the same time loud bursts of laughter, caused, no doubt, by the strange figure of Bazin, and issuing from the same carriage, left, as it were, a train of joy upon the passage of the rapid cortège.

‘My brave Mousqueton,’ resumed D’Artagnan, ‘pardon me, but I was so absorbed in your charming recital that I have forgotten the principal object of our conversation, which was to learn what M. le Vicaire-General d’Herblay could have to write to your master about.’

‘That is true, monsieur,’ said Mousqueton; ‘the pleasures have misled us. Well, monsieur, this is the whole affair.’

‘I am all attention, Mousqueton.’

‘On Wednesday—’

‘The day of the rustic pleasures?’

‘Yes—a letter arrived; he received it from my hands. I had recognized the writing.’

‘Well?’

Monsieur read it and cried out, ‘Quick, my horses! my arms!’

‘Oh, good Lord! then it was for some duel?’ said D’Artagnan.

‘No, monsieur, there were only these words: “Dear Porthos, set out, if you would wish to arrive before the Equinox. I expect you.”’

‘Mordieux!’ said D’Artagnan, thoughtfully, ‘that was pressing, apparently.’

‘I think so; therefore,’ continued Mousqueton, ‘monseigneur set out the very same day with his secretary, in order to endeavour to arrive in time.’

‘And did he arrive in time?’

‘I hope so. Monseigneur, who is hasty, as you know, monsieur, repeated incessantly, “Tonne Dieu! What can this mean? The Equinox? Never mind, a fellow must be well mounted to arrive before I do.”’

‘And you think Porthos will have arrived first, do you?’ asked D’Artagnan.

‘I am sure of it. This Equinox, however rich he may be, has certainly no horses so good as monseigneur’s.’

D’Artagnan repressed his inclination to laugh, because the brevity of Aramis’s letter gave rise to reflection. He followed Mousqueton, or rather Mousqueton’s chariot, to the castle. He sat down to a sumptuous table, of which they did him the honours as to a king. But he could draw nothing from Mousqueton,—the faithful servant seemed to shed tears at will, but that was all.

D'Artagnan, after a night passed in an excellent bed, reflected much upon the meaning of Aramis's letter; puzzled himself as to the relation of the Equinox with the affairs of Porthos; and being unable to make anything out unless it concerned some amour of the bishop's, for which it was necessary that the days and nights should be equal, D'Artagnan left Pierrefonds as he had left Melun, as he had left the château of the Comte de la Fère. It was not, however, without a melancholy, which might in good sooth pass for one of the most dismal of D'Artagnan's moods. His head cast down, his eyes fixed, he suffered his legs to hang on each side of his horse, and said to himself, in that vague sort of reverie which ascends sometimes to the sublimest eloquence:

'No more friends! no more future! no more anything! My energies are broken like the bonds of our ancient friendship. Oh, old age is coming, cold and inexorable; it envelopes in its funeral crepe all that was brilliant, all that was embalming in my youth; then it throws that sweet burthen on its shoulders and carries it away with the rest into the fathomless gulf of death.'

A shudder crept through the heart of the Gascon, so brave and so strong against all the misfortunes of life; and during some moments the clouds appeared black to him, the earth slippery and full of pits as that of cemeteries.

'Whither am I going?' said he to himself. 'What am I going to do! Alone, quite alone—without family, without friends! Bah!' cried he all at once. And he clapped spurs to his horse, who, having found nothing melancholy in the heavy oats of Pierrefonds, profited by this permission to show his gayety in a gallop which absorbed two leagues. 'To Paris!' said D'Artagnan to himself. And on the morrow he alighted in Paris. He had devoted ten days to this journey.

Bazin turned round and ordered the eldest of the pupils to inform the cook. In the meantime, D'Artagnan surveyed the presbytery.

'Phew!' said he, disdainfully, 'monseigneur lodged his grandeur very meanly here.'

'We have the château de Vaux,' said Bazin.

'Which is perhaps equal to the Louvre?' said D'Artagnan, jeeringly.

'Which is better,' replied Bazin, with the greatest coolness imaginable. 'Ah, ah!' said D'Artagnan.

He would perhaps have prolonged the discussion, and maintained the superiority of the Louvre, but the lieutenant perceived that his horse remained fastened to the bars of a gate.

'The devil!' said he. 'Get my horse looked after; your master the bishop has none like him in his stables.'

Bazin cast a sidelong glance at the horse, and replied, 'Monsieur le surintendant gave him four from his own stables; and each of the four is worth four of yours.'

The blood mounted to the face of D'Artagnan. His hand itched and his eye glanced over the head of Bazin, to select the place upon which he should discharge his anger. But it passed away; reflection came, and D'Artagnan contented himself with saying,—

'The devil! the devil! I have done well to quit the service of the king. Tell me, worthy Master Bazin,' added he, 'how many musketeers does monsieur le surintendant retain in his service?'

'He could have all there are in the kingdom with his money,' replied Bazin, closing his book, and dismissing the boys with some kindly blows of his cane.

'The devil! the devil!' repeated D'Artagnan, once more, as if to annoy the pedagogue. But as supper was now announced, he followed the cook, who introduced him into the refectory, where it awaited him. D'Artagnan placed himself at the table, and began a hearty attack upon his fowl.

'It appears to me,' said D'Artagnan, biting with all his might at the tough fowl they had served up to him, and which they had evidently forgotten to fatten,—'it appears that I have done wrong in not seeking service with that master yonder. A powerful noble this intendant, seemingly! In good truth, we poor fellows know nothing at the court, and the rays of

'He is right there,' said D'Artagnan, looking attentively at the house, the aspect of which announced solitude.

'But monseigneur must have written you an account of his promotion.'

'When did it take place?'

'A month back.'

'Oh! then there is no time lost. Aramis cannot yet have wanted me.

But how is it, Bazin, you do not follow your master?'

'Monsieur, I cannot; I have occupations.'

'Your alphabet?'

'And my penitents.'

'What, do you confess, then? Are you a priest?'

'The same as one. I have such a call.'

'But the orders?'

'Oh,' said Bazin, without hesitation, 'now that monseigneur is a bishop, I shall soon have my orders, or at least my dispensations.' And he rubbed his hands.

'Decidedly,' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'there will be no means of uprooting these people. Get me some supper, Bazin.'

'With pleasure, monsieur.'

'A fowl, a bouillon, and a bottle of wine.'

'This is Saturday night, monsieur—it is a day of abstinence.'

'I have a dispensation,' said D'Artagnan.

Bazin looked at him suspiciously.

'Ah, ah, master hypocrite!' said the musketeer, 'for whom do you take me? If you, who are the valet, hope for dispensation to commit a crime, shall not I, the friend of your bishop, have dispensation for eating meat at the call of my stomach? Make yourself agreeable with me, Bazin, or by heavens! I will complain to the king, and you shall never confess. Now you know that the nomination of bishops rests with the king—I have the king; I am the stronger.'

Bazin smiled hypocritically. 'Ah, but we have monsieur le surintendant,' said he.

'And you laugh at the king, then?'

Bazin made no reply; his smile was sufficiently eloquent.

'My supper,' said D'Artagnan, 'it is getting towards seven o'clock.'

Chapter XIX

What D'Artagnan Went to Paris For



HE lieutenant dismounted before a shop in the Rue des Lombards, at the sign of the Pilon d'Or. A man of good appearance, wearing a white apron, and stroking his gray moustache with a large hand, uttered a cry of joy on perceiving the pied horse. 'Monsieur le chevalier,' said he, 'ah, is that you?'

'Bon jour, Planchet,' replied D'Artagnan, stooping to enter the shop.

'Quick, somebody,' cried Planchet, 'to look after Monsieur d'Artagnan's horse,—somebody to get ready his room,—somebody to prepare his supper.'

'Thanks, Planchet. Good-day, my children!' said D'Artagnan to the eager boys.

'Allow me to send off this coffee, this treacle, and these raisins,' said Planchet; 'they are for the store-room of monsieur le surintendant.'

'Send them off, send them off!'

'That is only the affair of a moment, then we shall sup.'

'Arrange it that we may sup alone; I want to speak to you.'

Planchet looked at his old master in a significant manner.

'Oh, don't be uneasy, it is nothing unpleasant,' said D'Artagnan.

'So much the better—so much the better!' And Planchet breathed freely again, whilst D'Artagnan seated himself quietly down in the shop, upon a bale of corks, and made a survey of the premises. The shop was well stocked; there was a mingled perfume of ginger, cinnamon, and ground pepper, which made D'Artagnan sneeze. The shop-boy, proud of being in

company with so renowned a warrior, of a lieutenant of musketeers, who approached the person of the king, began to work with an enthusiasm which was something like delirium, and to serve the customers with a disdainful haste that was noticed by several.

Planchet put away his money, and made up his accounts, amidst civilities addressed to his former master. Planchet had with his equals the short speech and haughty familiarity of the rich shopkeeper who serves everybody and waits for nobody. D'Aragnan observed this habit with a pleasure which we shall analyse presently. He saw night come on by degrees, and at length Planchet conducted him to a chamber on the first story, where, amidst bales and chests, a table very nicely set out awaited the two guests.

D'Aragnan took advantage of a moment's pause to examine the countenance of Planchet, whom he had not seen for a year. The shrewd Planchet had acquired a slight protuberance in front, but his countenance was not puffed. His keen eye still played with facility in its deep-sunk orbit; and fat, which levels all the characteristic saliences of the human face, had not yet touched either his high cheek-bones, the sign of cunning and cupidity, or his pointed chin, the sign of acuteness and perseverance. Planchet reigned with as much majesty in his dining-room as in his shop. He set before his master a frugal, but perfectly Parisian repast: roast meat, cooked at the baker's, with vegetables, salad, and a dessert borrowed from the shop itself. D'Aragnan was pleased that the grocer had drawn from behind the fagots a bottle of that Anjou wine which during all his life had been D'Aragnan's favourite wine.

'Formerly, monsieur,' said Planchet, with a smile full of bonhomie, 'it was I who drank your wine; now you do me the honour to drink mine.'

'And, thank God, friend Planchet, I shall drink it for a long time to come, I hope; for at present I am free.'

'Free? You have a leave of absence, monsieur?'

'Unlimited.'

'You are leaving the service?' said Planchet, stupefied.

'Yes, I am resting.'

'And the king?' cried Planchet, who could not suppose it possible that the king could do without the services of such a man as D'Aragnan.

'Hush! hush!' said Bazin, opening his eyes: 'do not spoil these poor children, in whom I am endeavouring to inculcate such good principles.' In fact, the children had surrounded D'Aragnan, whose horse, long sword, spurs, and martial air they very much admired. But above all, they admired his strong voice; so that, when he uttered his oath, the whole school cried out, 'The devil take me!' with fearful bursts of laughter, shouts, and bounds, which delighted the musketeer, and bewildered the old pedagogue.

'There!' said he, 'hold your tongues, you brats! You have come, M. d'Aragnan, and all my good principles fly away. With you, as usual, comes disorder. Babel is revived. Ah! Good Lord! Ah! the wild little wretches!' And the worthy Bazin distributed right and left blows which increased the cries of his scholars by changing the nature of them.

'At least,' said he, 'you will no longer decoy any one here.'

'Do you think so?' said D'Aragnan, with a smile which made a shudder creep over the shoulders of Bazin.

'He is capable of it,' murmured he.

'Where is your master's diocese?'

'Monsieur Rene is bishop of Vannes.'

'Who had him nominated?'

'Why, monsieur le surintendant, our neighbour.'

'What! Monsieur Fouquet?'

'To be sure he did.'

'Is Aramis on good terms with him, then?'

'Monsieur preached every Sunday at the house of monsieur le surintendant at Vaux; then they hunted together.'

'Ah!'

'And monsieur composed his homilies—no, I mean his sermons—with monsieur le surintendant.'

'Bah! he preached in verse, then, this worthy bishop?'

'Monsieur, for the love of heaven, do not jest with sacred things.'

'There, Bazin, there! So, then, Aramis is at Vannes?'

'At Vannes, in Bretagne.'

'You are a deceitful old hunk, Bazin; that is not true.'

'See, monsieur, if you please; the apartments of the presbytery are empty.'

fault, in his experience of thirty years, and in a great habit of reading the physiognomies of houses, as well as those of men. At Melun, D'Artagnan immediately found the presbytery—a charming house, plastered over red brick, with vines climbing along the gutters, and a cross, in carved stone, surmounting the ridge of the roof. From the ground-floor of this house came a noise, or rather a confusion of voices, like the chirping of young birds when the brood is just hatched under the down. One of these voices was spelling the alphabet distinctly. A voice thick, yet pleasant, at the same time scolded the talkers and corrected the faults of the reader. D'Artagnan recognized that voice, and as the window of the ground-floor was open, he leant down from his horse under the branches and red fibres of the vine and cried, 'Bazin, my dear Bazin! good-day to you.'

A short, fat man, with a flat face, a cranium ornamented with a crown of gray hairs, cut short, in imitation of a tonsure, and covered with an old black velvet cap, arose as soon as he heard D'Artagnan—we ought not to say arose, but bounded up. In fact, Bazin bounded up, carrying with him his little low chair, which the children tried to take away, with battles more fierce than those of the Greeks endeavouring to recover the body of Patroclus from the hands of the Trojans. Bazin did more than bound; he let fall both his alphabet and his fénule. 'You!' said he, 'you, Monsieur D'Artagnan?'

'Yes, myself! Where is Aramis—no, M. le Chevalier d'Herblay—no, I am still mistaken—Monsieur le Vicaire-General?'

'Ah, monsieur,' said Bazin, with dignity, 'monseigneur is at his diocese.'

'What did you say?' said D'Artagnan. Bazin repeated the sentence.

'Ah, ah! but has Aramis a diocese?'

'Yes, monsieur. Why not?'

'Is he a bishop, then?'

'Why, where can you come from,' said Bazin, rather irreverently, 'that you don't know that?'

'My dear Bazin, we pagans, we men of the sword, know very well when a man is made a colonel, or maitre-de-camp, or marshal of France, but if he be made a bishop, arch-bishop, or pope—devil take me if the news reaches us before the three quarters of the earth have had the advantage of it!'

'The king will try his fortune elsewhere. But we have supped well, you are disposed to enjoy yourself; you invite me to confide in you. Open your ears, then.'

'They are open.' And Planchet, with a laugh more frank than cunning, opened a bottle of white wine.

'Leave me my reason, at least.'

'Oh, as to you losing your head—you, monsieur!'

'Now my head is my own, and I mean to take better care of it than ever. In the first place we shall talk business. How fares our money-box?'

'Wonderfully well, monsieur. The twenty thousand livres I had of you are still employed in my trade, in which they bring me nine per cent. I give you seven, so I gain two by you.'

'And you are still satisfied?'

'Delighted. Have you brought me any more?'

'Better than that. But do you want any?'

'Oh! not at all. Every one is willing to trust me now. I am extending my business.'

'That was your intention.'

'I play the banker a little. I buy goods of my needy brethren; I lend money to those who are not ready for their payments.'

'Without usury?'

'Oh! monsieur, in the course of the last week I have had two meetings on the boulevards, on account of the word you have just pronounced.'

'What?'

'You shall see: it concerned a loan. The borrower gives me in pledge some raw sugars, on condition that I should sell if repayment were not made within a fixed period. I lend a thousand livres. He does not pay me, and I sell the sugars for thirteen hundred livres. He learns this and claims a hundred crowns. Ma foi! I refused, pretending that I could not sell them for more than nine hundred livres. He accused me of usury. I begged him to repeat that word to me behind the boulevards. He was an old guard, and he came: and I passed your sword through his left thigh.'

'Tu diens! what a pretty sort of banker you make!' said D'Artagnan.

'For above thirteen per cent I fight,' replied Planchet, 'that is my character.'

'Take only twelve,' said D'Artagnan, 'and call the rest premium and brokerage.'

'You are right, monsieur; but to your business.'

'Ah! Planchet, it is very long and very hard to speak.'

'Do speak it, nevertheless.'

D'Artagnan twisted his moustache like a man embarrassed with the confidence he is about to make and mistrustful of his confidant.

'Is it an investment?' asked Planchet.

'Why, yes.'

'At good profit?'

'A capital profit,—four hundred per cent, Planchet.'

Planchet gave such a blow with his fist upon the table, that the bottles bounded as if they had been frightened.

'Good heavens! is that possible?'

'I think it will be more,' replied D'Artagnan coolly; 'but I like to lay it at the lowest!'

'The devil!' said Planchet, drawing nearer. 'Why, monsieur, that is magnificent! Can one put much money in it?'

'Twenty thousand livres each, Planchet.'

'Why, that is all you have, monsieur. For how long a time?'

'For a month.'

'And that will give us—'

'Fifty thousand livres each, profit.'

'It is monstrous! It is worth while to fight for such interest as that!'

'In fact, I believe it will be necessary to fight not a little,' said D'Artagnan, with the same tranquillity; 'but this time there are two of us, Planchet, and I shall take all the blows to myself.'

'Oh! monsieur, I will not allow that.'

'Planchet, you cannot be concerned in it; you would be obliged to leave your business and your family.'

'The affair is not in Paris, then.'

'No.'

'Abroad?'

'In England.'

'A speculative country, that is true,' said Planchet,—'a country that I know well. What sort of an affair, monsieur, without too much curiosity?'

'No, monsieur; for then M. Grimaud would have broken his word; he would have perjured himself, and that is impossible.'

'That is impossible,' repeated D'Artagnan, quite in a study, because he was quite convinced. 'Well, my brave Blaisois, many thanks to you.'

Blaisois bowed.

'Come, you know I am not curious—I have serious business with your master. Could you not, by a little bit of a word—you who speak so well—give me to understand—one syllable only—I will guess the rest.'

'Upon my word, monsieur, I cannot. I am quite ignorant where monsieur le comte is gone. As to listening at doors, that is contrary to my nature; and besides, it is forbidden here.'

'My dear fellow,' said D'Artagnan, 'this is a very bad beginning for me. Never mind; you know when monsieur le comte will return, at least?'

'As little, monsieur, as the place of his destination.'

'Come, Blaisois, come, search.'

'Monsieur doubts my sincerity? Ah, monsieur, that grieves me much.'

'The devil take his gilded tongue!' grumbled D'Artagnan. 'A clown with a word would be worth a dozen of him. Adieu!'

'Monsieur, I have the honour to present you my respects.'

'Cuiestre!' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'the fellow is unbearable.' He gave another look up to the house, turned his horse's head, and set off like a man who has nothing either annoying or embarrassing in his mind. When he was at the end of the wall, and out of sight,—'Well, now, I wonder,' said he, breathing quickly, 'whether Athos was at home. No; all those idlers, standing with their arms crossed, would have been at work if the eye of the master was near. Athos gone on a journey?—that is incomprehensible. Bah! it is all devilish mysterious! And then—no—he is not the man I want. I want one of a cunning, patient mind. My business is at Melun, in a certain presbytery I am acquainted with. Forty-five leagues—four days and a half! Well, it is fine weather, and I am free. Never mind the distance!'

And he put his horse into a trot, directing his course towards Paris. On the fourth day he alighted at Melun, as he had intended.

D'Artagnan was never in the habit of asking any one on the road for any common information. For these sorts of details, unless in very serious circumstances, he confided in his perspicacity, which was so seldom at